THE UN SECRETARIAT AND THE SECRETARY-GENERAL

Secretary-General

At Dumbarton Oaks, this particular post was given prime importance and the Secretary-General was described as the "Chief Administrative Officer of the UN". He was invested with greater power by the Charter as compared with the league Covenant which restricted the powers of the Secretary-General to the point that "he shall act in such capacity at all meetings of the Assembly and Council". But the Preparatory Commission at San Francisco went further and established the importance of the Secretary-General by highlighting the executive role as a "quite special right, which goes beyond any power previously accorded to the head of an international organization".

Appointment

Chapter XV of the Charter contains provisions relating to the powers and functions of the Secretary-General and his Secretariat. Article 97 states that the Secretariat shall comprise a Secretary-General and such staff as the Organization may require. The Secretary-General shall be appointed by the General Assembly on the recommendation of the Security Council. He shall be the Chief Administrative Officer of the Organization. The term of office has not been specified by the Charter but a General Assembly resolution fixed the term for five years with the provision of reappointment also.

Functions and Powers

Combining in himself the roles of a diplomat, advocate, civil servant and CEO, the Secretary-General is a symbol of the United Nations' ideals and a spokesman for the interests of the world's peoples, in particular the poor and the vulnerable among them. The current Secretary-General, and the eighth occupant of the post, is Mr. Ban Ki-moon of the Republic of Korea (South Korea), who took office on 1 January 2007.

Being the Chief Administrative Officer of the UN, he plays a pivotal role in the overall administration of the UN. From being the chief